

COMPETITIONS – Context and Purpose

Context

- DEP-funded advanced digital skills initiatives (Advanced Digital Skills Academies, specialised education and training programmes, CSAs)
- Digital Decade target of 20 million ICT specialists by 2030

Purpose

- Nurture advanced digital skills talent in the EU
- Ensure cooperation with ELEVATE and other relevant DEP-funded projects
- Centralise visibility and engagement through the Digital Skills and Jobs Platform

COMPETITIONS – Objectives and Structure

Objective:

- Addressing highly relevant European or local societal, technological and/or industry relevant challenges by engaging young European people in cutting edge digital technologies.

Structure:

- Six competitions: AI, Virtual Worlds, quantum, semiconductors, Destination Earth initiative, an additional area chosen by the consortium.
- Minimum three challenges per each competition.
- Competing teams: students from tertiary education institutions or equivalent, from at least 4 different education and training institutions from 4 different Member States or countries associated with the DIGITAL.

COMPETITIONS – Outcomes and Deliverables

Outcomes:

- Implementation and roll-out of 6 distinct competitions in the 6 digital areas
- An award ceremony organised in Brussels
- Involvement of industry stakeholders

Deliverables:

- Well defined, up to date and relevant challenges for the Competitions
- Competitions rule book for participants and jury
- Competitions implementation roadmap
- Implementation and roll-out of the six competitions
- Sustainability plans for the proposed competitions after the end of the project

COMPETITION – Consortium Composition

Recommended consortium composition:

higher education institutions, vocational education and training institutions, other education and training providers, industry partners, research institutes, centres of excellence, public administrations and/or governmental bodies, IT professionals.

What evaluators will look for:

- Number of challenges per competition
- Number of teams per competition
- Number of participants per competition
- Number of Member States and DIGITAL associated countries represented in each competition
- Number of people reached through the communication campaign(s)
- Number of events organised (online and physical)
- Gender target

Digital Call 9 - 2 topics

Call	DIGITAL-2026-SKILLS-09	Type of Action	Funding Rate	Available budget
Topic	DIGITAL-2026-SKILLS-09-LEAGUE-OF-ACADEMIES ELEVATE - European League of Advanced Digital Skills Academies	Coordination and Support Actions (CSA)	100%	EUR 7 200 000
Topic	DIGITAL-2026-SKILLS-09-COMPETITIONS European Advanced Digital Skills Competitions	Coordination and Support Actions (CSA)	100%	EUR 7 000 000

 Link to the Call page on the Funding and Tenders Portal: [Advanced Digital Skills](#)

Digital Call 9 – Timeline

Phases	Dates
Call opening	04 November 2025
Deadline for submission	03 March 2026 @17:00 CET (Brussels)
Evaluation	April – May 2026
Information on evaluation results	June 2026
Grant Agreement Signature	by September 2026

Award criteria



See Call document - Section 9 – *Award Criteria*, for detailed information.

1. RELEVANCE	2. IMPLEMENTATION	3. IMPACT
1.1 Alignment with the objectives and activities as described in section 2 1.2 Contribution to long-term policy objectives, relevant policies and strategies, and synergies with activities at European and national level <i>1.3 Extent to which the project would reinforce and secure the digital technology supply chain in the EU*</i> <i>1.4 Extent to which the project can overcome financial obstacles such as the lack of market finance*</i>	2.1 Maturity of the project 2.2 Soundness of the implementation plan and efficient use of resources 2.3 Capacity of the applicants, and when applicable the consortium as a whole, to carry out the proposed work	3.1 Extent to which the project will achieve the expected outcomes and deliverables referred to in the call for proposals and, where relevant, the plans to disseminate and communicate project achievements 3.2 Extent to which the project will strengthen competitiveness and bring important benefits for society <i>3.3 Extent to which the project addresses environmental sustainability and the European Green Deal goals, in terms of direct effects and/or in awareness of environmental effects*</i>



Sub-criteria 1.3, 1.4 and 3.3 are **NOT APPLICABLE** in this Call. See Call document - Section 2 – *Specific topic conditions*

Award criteria and thresholds

Award criteria	Minimum pass score per criterion	Minimum pass score per proposal	Maximum score per criterion	Maximum score per proposal
Relevance	3	10	5	15
Implementation	3		5	
Impact	3		5	

For a proposal to be considered for funding, it **MUST**:

Obtain at least **score 3** in **all three criteria** **AND** Obtain an **overall score** of or above **10**

- Proposals *below* individual or overall score → *rejected*.
- Proposals *above* individual and overall thresholds and within the limits of the *available call budget* → *can be funded*.
- For further details, please refer to the Call Document Section 9 – Award Criteria.

Final tips for applicants



- **Admissibility requirements:**

- Application form **is readable** – before uploading Part B to the submission system, check that it has been correctly converted to PDF and that there are no missing parts or missing tables.
- Always use the **standard template Part B** downloaded from the Submission System (not an old copy or own format).
- **Do not modify** the template
- **List of previous projects** – mandatory Annex (see template for it in Part B)

- **Eligibility requirement:**

- **Consortium composition compliance is a must** – Read carefully Section 6 of the call document and the section *Targeted Stakeholders* for each topic.

Final tips for applicants



- **Security issues tables in Part A:**
 - Security: Applicable (fill in the Security table in Part A)
 - Mark with great attention the **relevant Security issues** when applicable
 - When marking any security issues, include the corresponding **proposal Part B page** in the Security table
- **Award Criteria:**
 - Take into account the **award criteria** as detailed in the Call document and follow that logic in your application to provide all necessary information.
 - *Call document Section 2 – Scope*
 - *Call document Section 9 – Award criteria*

Final tips for applicants



- **Part B page Limit:**
 - **50 pages (CSA).** Any additional pages will not be taken into account.
- **Deadline:**
 - **Do not submit your proposal on the last day** to avoid last minute or technical problems! Resubmission before the deadline is possible.
- **Overlaps/double funding risk:**
 - The system detects similarities between proposals. This has serious legal implications.
 - Reply relevant questions in Part A carefully.
- **Updates to the Call/Topics and Q&As:**
 - Regularly check **possible updates** to the call or topics and new **Topic specific Q&As**.

Thank you for your attention

**For any questions after today's session please submit them
through the form in the F&T Portal:**

[Write to us](#)



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